

TARANGA GOGOI, 37

BJP MLA, Naharkatia, Assam

Able Lieutenant

When Taranga Gogoi contested his first assembly poll this April from Naharkatia in Assam, not many fancied his victory. The young debutant was up against three high-profile candidates—Pranati Phukan, a former minister and four-time MLA; Lurinjyoti Gogoi, Assam Jatiya Parishad president and poster boy of the state-wide protest against Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019, and Naren Sonowal, sitting MLA from Asom Gana Parishad. Yet, he went on to win a multi-cornered contest by a margin of nearly 15,000 votes—the 2016 margin was just over 3,500.

Son of a PWD contractor and housewife mother, Taranga entered politics as a National Students' Union of India member in Delhi in 2003. He rose to become national secretary and in-charge of Kerala, Bihar and the Northeast. Thanks to his work in mobilising votes in campus elections in Delhi and Assam, he came to the then Assam Congress minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's notice. Gogoi has been a Sarma loyalist since, joining BJP with him in 2015, and rising to become state secretary. He retains Sarma's as well as his predecessor Sarbananda Sonowal's confidence, despite their differences. Taranga's success is the result of a conscious effort to project himself as a grounded, soft-speaking politician who believes in deliverance more than the decibel level of his promises. ■

– Kaushik Deka

> **"Taranga is one of Assam's most promising and energetic young politicians who has made his mark through merit, fresh ideas and hard work"**
>
> **SARBANANDA SONOWAL** *Union Minister of Ports, Shipping & Waterways and AYUSH*

SHUTTLE SERVICE Taranga, who wanted to be a badminton player, now plays with Chief Minister Sarma whenever both are in Guwahati